

Scanning for malware and viruses

Viruses could lead to problems with the excel file not opening at all. Upon opening a malware could have already scanned the data and made it corrupt if it was affected. If the file was transferred over by a client who had a virus, then there could be problems here as well. A malware-infected excel sheet could have raised red flags across the board, which is why a comprehensive anti-virus is necessary.

Troubleshooting starts from cleaning out the file completely. You can also rid the source of the file of viruses as well so that you can get a clean slate. Now you can try to open the file using a compliant file extension and software package. There are chances where the file may not have been the target of a virus attack, but the data is lost, nonetheless. In this case, it's best to recover using a hard-recover method.

Antiviruses can help you recover the file in many cases. When the virus is cleaned off, it's best to password protect the file if there is sensitive information present. Nowadays, ransomware and crypto-jacking are also becoming increasingly common. Hackers target Excel sheets as they're more likely to contain important company data.

While you may have a clean file, you may not be able to recover some of the data as well. In this case, you need to use the default Open & Repair method that Microsoft offers. The tool can update your file towards new security patches and increase the readability of the data present. While this is the last recovery option, you can also copy paste multiple versions of the file and try opening them with a variety of different software outside of MS Excel.

File type and compatibility

More often than not the person may have opened the wrong file type. A .xls may not be compatible with a .csv which means that a legacy computer may have to be brought in to check it out. The file can also be opened via other programs outside of Excel that may open the information up. It may be the best hope for the recovery of the previous data.

Additionally, if the name of the file has been changed to a cryptic name with a different file type, then there could be compatibility issues there as well. You can run the file as administrator to see if there are any differences in opening the file in either format. You may also try opening the file in an older version of the Excel format.

You can also disconnect Excel from the internet, as the file may be trying to retrieve information from an online source. It may have a badly linked